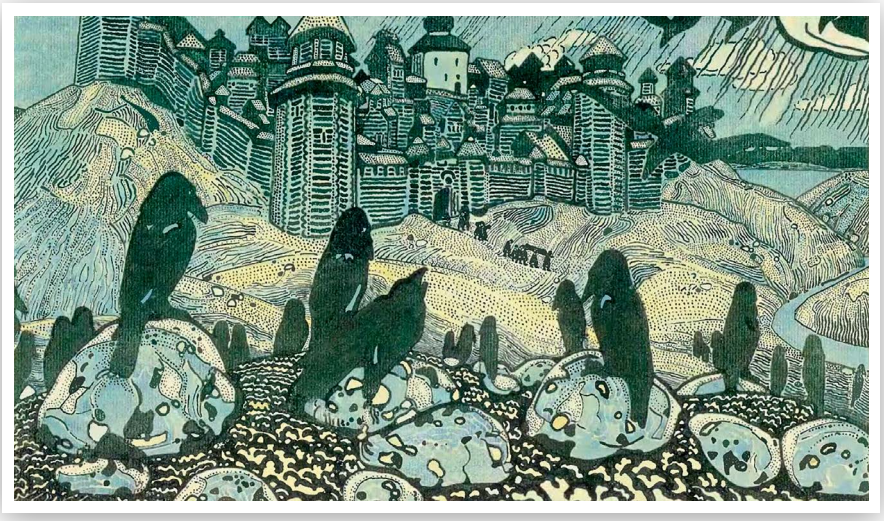
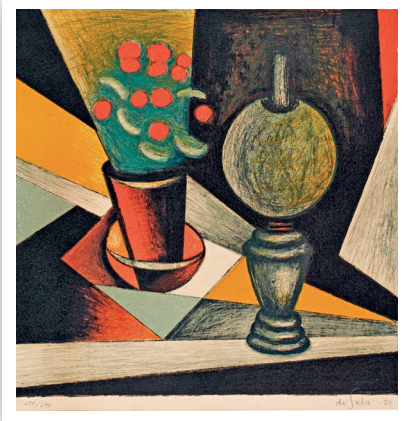






**LASTING IMPRESSIONS**
**Clockwise from left: N. Roerich's 'Town (Ominous)'; A. Ramachandran's 'Roski as a Young Bride'; an artwork by Eugène de Sala**

▶ ART

# Print is Not Dead

**An exhibition at New Delhi's Dhoomimal Gallery examines the heritage of printmaking and its emerging future in the age of AI**

It's well-documented that printmaking dates back to the earliest eras of human history. Long before the process was upscaled and industrialised, printmaking was a way to record and disseminate cultural information in a widely accessible format. The past and present of printmaking as an artistic enterprise are the focus of *Print Age*, an ongoing exhibition at Delhi's Dhoomimal Gallery. Curated by Johny M.L., *Print Age* brings together a total of 156 prints from 80 individuals, including globally famous artists like Pablo Picasso, Marc Chagall and Anish Kapoor, as well as Indian printmakers like Jyoti Bhatt and Laxma Goud. The exhibition, open to the public until March 15, showcases several forms of printmaking, including lithographs, woodcuts, drypoints, etchings, linocuts, et al.

**PRINT AGE SHOWCASES SEVERAL FORMS OF PRINTMAKING—LITHOGRAPHS, WOODCUTS, DRYPOINTS, ETCHINGS, LINOCUTS, ETC.**

Talking about *Print Age*, Johny says, "In the Indian context, if you look at the cave paintings of Bhimbetka, it doesn't match the modern, industrial definition of printmaking. But it is definitely a precursor to it. Printmaking was a kind of popular art form that did not depend upon literacy—you could be an unlettered person and still completely understand what the artist is trying to depict in the print. It was only much later, after Gutenberg's invention of the press, that prints started to be used to illustrate books." For instance, Chagall's 'Le Mise en Mots' (11x8.5 inches, lithograph, 1960), which is a part of *Print Age*, was originally created as a frontispiece for the Russian-French writer Elsa Triolet's book of the same name.

The subtitle for *Print Age* is 'The art of printmaking in the age of AI reproduction'. As it indicates, advancements in AI-based technology mean that printmakers today have to reassess and, if necessary, rethink their commercial approach. Johny says, "We are living in a technologically saturated era, where even Gen-Z youngsters have this nostalgia for more tactile, old-fashioned artefacts because these are perceived to be more meaningful than tech-mediated products. Hopefully, the demand for printmaking will continue to rise because of this phenomenon." ■

***—Aditya Mani Jha***

*At Dhoomimal Gallery, New Delhi, until Mar. 15*